The ABCDE Approach

AIRWAY

Can the patient talk?

YES → Patent

NO →

- Open the mouth
- Inspect for anything obviously compromising the airway (e.g. secretions)

BREATHING

Look for:

- Use of accessory musclea
- diminished breath sounds
- added sounds
- Cyanosis

Check

- Respiratory rate
- Oxygen saturation (88%-92% in COPD; 94%-98% otherwise)

CIRCULATION

Check

- Pulses
- peripheries (warm/cold/cyanosed)
- Capillary refill time (N < 2 sec)
- Insert cannula (at least 1 wide-bore IV cannula (14G or 16G)

DISABILITY

Check

- Level of consciousness
- Glasgow coma scale (GCS)

EXPOSURE

- Expose the patient for a full assessment (if necessary)
- Remember to prioritize patient dignity and conservation of body heat